

BONUS 4 OF 5

How to Price & Sell

Calculate costs, set margins, take phone photos that sell and handle discount requests.

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SECTION 1

Calculating Your Real Cost Per Backpack

Know exactly what every backpack costs you before you set a price.

Most makers undercharge because they only count yarn. A real cost includes materials, time and overhead. Until you know the true number, every sale is a guess.

The Three-Part Cost Formula

Your total cost per backpack has three layers:

COST LAYER	WHAT IT INCLUDES	HOW TO CALCULATE
Materials	Yarn, lining fabric, zipper, hardware, thread, labels	Add the price of every item used, including partial skeins
Labor	Your time crocheting, assembling, finishing	Hours worked × your hourly rate
Overhead	Packaging, tags, shipping supplies, marketplace fees, electricity, hooks worn out	Estimate monthly total ÷ items made per month

Step by Step

- 1 List every material** — weigh leftover yarn to figure out how much you actually used. If a skein makes two backpacks, divide the cost by two.
- 2 Time yourself once** — set a timer from the first chain to the last weave-in. Write it down. Round up to the nearest half hour.
- 3 Pick an hourly rate** — decide what your time is worth. It can be minimum wage or higher — but it cannot be zero. Many makers start with the minimum wage in their area and increase as they gain experience.
- 4 Add overhead per item** — total your monthly fixed costs (packaging, marketplace subscription, supplies) and divide by the number of items you expect to sell that month.
- 5 Sum the three layers** — this is your true cost. Write it on a sticky note and keep it visible.

Do this

Keep a simple spreadsheet or notebook with one row per backpack style: materials cost, hours, labor cost, overhead, total cost. Update it whenever yarn prices change.

Common mistake

Forgetting to count partial skeins, linings, zippers and hardware. A backpack with a lining and zipper can have more non-yarn cost than yarn cost. Count everything.

Sample Cost Worksheet

ITEM	QUANTITY	COST
Yarn (main color)	2.5 skeins	Your local price $\times$ 2.5
Yarn (accent color)	0.5 skein	Your local price $\times$ 0.5
Lining fabric	0.5 m / 0.5 yd	Your local price
Zipper	1	Your local price
Buckles / D-rings	2–4	Your local price
Thread, needle, label	1 set	Your local price
Materials subtotal		A
Labor	___ hours $\times$ rate	B
Overhead per item	Monthly total $\div$ items	C
Total cost (A + B + C)		---

Cost Calculation Checklist

- ☐ Weighed or measured yarn actually used (not just full skeins)
- ☐ Included lining, zipper and all hardware
- ☐ Timed myself making one complete backpack
- ☐ Chose an hourly rate and wrote it down
- ☐ Calculated monthly overhead and divided by items
- ☐ Summed all three layers into a single cost number

SECTION 2

Setting Your Price

Turn your cost into a price that covers expenses, pays you fairly and feels right to buyers.

Price is not about being the cheapest. It is about knowing your cost, choosing a margin that sustains your craft, and communicating the value so buyers understand what they are getting.

The Multiplier Method

Start with your total cost (from Section 1) and multiply:

MULTIPLIER	WHEN TO USE	WHAT IT COVERS
2× cost	Selling directly to friends, family, at local markets	Covers cost + a basic profit margin
2.5× cost	Selling online through your own page or social media	Covers cost + profit + marketing time
3× cost	Selling on marketplaces that charge fees	Covers cost + profit + platform fees + shipping materials
3.5–4× cost	Wholesale to shops (they will mark up further)	Covers cost + enough margin so both you and the shop earn

Perceived Value Boosters

These make buyers comfortable paying your price — no discounting needed:

Craftsmanship Signals

- Clean, even stitches (gauge swatch first)
- Lined interior with pockets
- Sturdy hardware and smooth zippers
- Woven-in ends that never poke out

Presentation Signals

- Professional-looking photos (see Section 3)
- Branded hang tag or sewn-in label
- Thoughtful packaging (see Section 7)
- Clear description of materials used

- 1 Pick your multiplier** — based on where you plan to sell. If you sell through multiple channels, price for the one with the highest fees and treat the rest as bonus margin.

- 2 **Check the range** — search for handmade crochet backpacks online. Your price should sit in the middle to upper range, not at the bottom. Cheap signals low quality.
- 3 **Round to a clean number** — prices ending in 0 or 5 look more professional for handmade goods than prices ending in .99.
- 4 **Test with three people** — tell them the price. If all three say “that’s it?” you are undercharging. If all three hesitate, check your presentation before lowering.

Do this

Write your price on a card and leave it next to the finished backpack for a day. If you feel embarrassed, the backpack is not the problem — your presentation is. Improve the photos, the description or the packaging first.

Common mistake

Pricing based on how long it “should” take instead of how long it actually takes. Use your real timer from Section 1, not an optimistic estimate.

Pricing Checklist

- ☐ Calculated price using the multiplier method
- ☐ Checked comparable handmade backpack prices online
- ☐ Price rounds to a clean number
- ☐ Tested the price with at least one person outside my household
- ☐ Price covers all three cost layers plus profit

SECTION 3

Phone Photography That Sells

Take photos that make people stop scrolling — using nothing but your phone and natural light.

The backpack someone sees in a photo is the backpack they decide to buy. Great photos do not need expensive equipment — they need good light, a clean background and a few simple angles.

Lighting

- 1 **Find your window** — place a table next to the largest window in your home. The window should be to the side of the backpack, not behind it and not directly above.
- 2 **Shoot during the day** — the best light is between mid-morning and mid-afternoon. Overcast days give soft, even light with no harsh shadows.
- 3 **Diffuse direct sun** — if sunlight hits the backpack directly, hang a white sheet or tape white baking paper over the window. This softens the light and removes hot spots.
- 4 **Add a reflector** — place a piece of white cardboard on the opposite side of the window to bounce light into the shadows. A white cutting board or foil-covered cardboard works too.

Common mistake

Using overhead room lights or the phone flash. Both create flat, yellowish photos that hide the stitch texture. Turn off all indoor lights and use only the window.

The Five Shots You Need

SHOT	WHAT IT SHOWS	HOW TO SET UP
Front flat lay	Overall shape, color, closure	Lay backpack flat on a clean surface, phone directly above, shoot straight down
Angled hero	Depth, dimension, how it sits	Prop the backpack up (stuff it with tissue), shoot at a 30–45° angle
Detail close-up	Stitch texture, hardware, label	Move in close, tap the screen to focus on the detail, hold steady

SHOT	WHAT IT SHOWS	HOW TO SET UP
Interior / open	Lining, pockets, zipper quality	Open the backpack, angle it toward the light, shoot from above
Scale / lifestyle	Size on a person, how straps look	Someone wears the backpack, natural pose, full body or waist-up

Backgrounds

Good Backgrounds

- White poster board or foam board
- Light wood table or cutting board
- Linen or cotton fabric (no wrinkles)
- Clean, neutral wall for held-up shots

Avoid

- Patterned tablecloths or bedsheets
- Cluttered tables with other objects
- Dark surfaces that absorb light
- Shiny or reflective surfaces

Quick Phone Settings

- 1 Clean the lens** — wipe it with a soft cloth before every session. Fingerprints cause haze.
- 2 Turn off the flash** — always. No exceptions.
- 3 Tap to focus** — tap the backpack on the screen so the phone focuses on the product, not the background.
- 4 Hold steady or prop** — lean your elbows on the table or stack books to rest the phone. Motion blur ruins photos.
- 5 Shoot at 1× zoom** — never use digital zoom. Move your body closer instead.

Do this

Take more photos than you think you need. Shoot 20–30, then pick the best 5. It is much easier to choose from many than to reshoot because nothing came out right.

Photo Session Checklist

- ☐ Window light from the side, indoor lights off
- ☐ Clean, neutral background set up
- ☐ Phone lens wiped clean
- ☐ Flash turned off
- ☐ Shot all five angles: flat lay, hero, detail, interior, lifestyle
- ☐ Reviewed photos at full size and deleted blurry ones

SECTION 4

Writing Descriptions That Convert

Write listing titles and descriptions that answer buyer questions before they ask.

A buyer who reads your description and still has questions will leave. A buyer who finds every answer they need will click “buy.” Your description does the selling when you are not there.

The Title Formula

Use this structure for every listing title:

[What It Is] + [Key Feature] + [Who It’s For or Occasion]

Examples:

- *Handmade Crochet Mini Backpack — Lined With Zip Closure — Everyday Carry*
- *Kids Crochet Backpack — Animal Ears — Gift for Toddlers*
- *Boho Crochet Drawstring Backpack — Cotton Yarn — Festival & Travel*

What to Include in the Description

- 1 Opening hook** — one sentence about the finished product, not the process. Focus on what the buyer gets: “A sturdy, fully lined backpack that holds a tablet, water bottle and essentials.”
- 2 Dimensions** — height, width and depth in both cm and inches. Measure the actual finished product, not the pattern dimensions.
- 3 Materials** — yarn fiber (cotton, acrylic, wool blend), lining fabric, hardware type. Buyers with allergies or preferences look for this.
- 4 Features bullet list** — use short, scannable bullets:
 - 5** Zip / drawstring / magnetic snap closure
 - 6** Interior pocket(s)
 - 7** Adjustable straps
 - 8** Machine washable — or care instructions

- 9 **Care instructions** — hand wash / machine wash cold / lay flat to dry. Be specific so the buyer feels confident.
- 10 **Shipping & processing** — estimated time to make (if made to order) and shipping timeframe.

Do this

Read your description out loud. If it sounds like you are talking about yourself (“I made this with love”), rewrite it to talk about the buyer (“You get a backpack that...”). The buyer cares about what it does for them.

Common mistake

Writing a paragraph about how much time it took or how hard it was. Buyers do not pay for difficulty — they pay for the result. Save the process story for social media posts, not the listing.

Description Template

TITLE

[What It Is] — [Key Feature] — [Who / Occasion]

DESCRIPTION

[One sentence: what the buyer gets and the main benefit.]

Details:

- Size: ___ cm / ___ in (H) × ___ cm / ___ in (W) × ___ cm / ___ in (D)
- Material: [yarn fiber], [lining], [hardware]
- Closure: [type]
- Interior: [pockets, lining color]
- Straps: [adjustable / fixed, length]

Care: [wash instructions]

Shipping: [processing time] + [shipping estimate]

Description Checklist

- ☐ Title follows the formula: What + Feature + Who
- ☐ Opening sentence focuses on the buyer, not the maker
- ☐ Dimensions listed in both cm and inches
- ☐ Materials and fiber content included
- ☐ Features listed as scannable bullets
- ☐ Care instructions included
- ☐ Shipping / processing time mentioned

SECTION 5

Where to Sell Handmade

Choose the right channels for your skill level, time and goals.

There is no single “best” place to sell. The right channel depends on how many backpacks you can make, how much time you have for shipping and customer service, and whether you prefer online or in-person sales.

Channel Comparison

CHANNEL	PROS	CONS	BEST FOR
Online marketplaces	Built-in traffic, search visibility, buyer trust	Fees per sale, competition, platform rules	Makers who can ship regularly and handle online orders
Your own website or page	No per-sale fees, full control, brand building	You drive all the traffic yourself, setup time	Makers with an existing social media following
Social media selling	Free to post, direct contact with buyers, fast feedback	No built-in checkout (some platforms), need consistent posting	Makers who enjoy creating content and engaging online
Local craft fairs & markets	Cash sales, no shipping, buyers see and touch the product	Table fee, travel, weather-dependent, limited dates	Makers who enjoy in-person interaction and live locally near events
Consignment in shops	No table fee, ongoing display, shop handles the sale	Shop takes a percentage, no control over display, slow payment	Makers who want passive sales and have local boutiques nearby
Word of mouth & custom orders	No fees, higher prices for custom work, personal connection	Unpredictable volume, scope creep on custom requests	Makers just starting out or with limited production capacity

Getting Started

- 1 Start with one channel** — do not spread yourself thin. Pick the one that matches your current capacity and learn it well before adding a second.

- 2 **Have inventory ready** — list at least three to five backpacks (or styles) so your shop does not look empty. One item alone rarely attracts buyers.
- 3 **Set up policies first** — decide on your return policy, processing time and shipping options before the first sale. Write them down and include them in every listing.
- 4 **Track what sells** — keep a simple log: date, item, channel, price, any notes. After ten sales you will see patterns that help you decide what to make next.

Do this

Before you open any shop, make three backpacks and photograph them all. A shop with three polished listings and good photos will outsell a shop with ten listings and blurry phone snapshots.

Common mistake

Listing on five platforms at once and then forgetting to update inventory. A buyer who orders an item you already sold somewhere else will leave a negative review. Start with one channel.

Sales Channel Checklist

- ☐ Chosen one primary sales channel
- ☐ At least three items ready to list with photos and descriptions
- ☐ Return / exchange policy written
- ☐ Processing time and shipping options decided
- ☐ Sales log or spreadsheet ready

SECTION 6

Handling “Can You Do It Cheaper?”

Respond to discount requests with confidence, keep the sale and protect your margins.

Discount requests are not insults — they are a sign that the buyer is interested but needs help understanding the value. Your response sets the tone for every future sale.

Why You Should Not Lower Your Price

- **It devalues all handmade work** — every maker who discounts trains buyers to expect cheap handmade goods.
- **It sets a precedent** — that buyer (and everyone they tell) will expect the same discount next time.
- **Your cost does not change** — a lower price means less pay for your time, not lower material costs.

Response Scripts

Use these as templates. Adjust the tone to match your style.

SCRIPT 1 — THE VALUE REFRAME

“Thank you for your interest! This backpack is handmade from start to finish — it takes me [X] hours of work, uses [material], and includes a full lining and quality hardware. The price reflects all of that. I’d love for you to have it!”

SCRIPT 2 — THE ALTERNATIVE OFFER

“I can’t lower the price on this design, but I do have a simpler style without the lining / hardware that costs less. Would you like to see it?”

SCRIPT 3 — THE BUNDLE INCENTIVE

“I keep my prices fair for the work involved, but if you order two or more I can offer free shipping (or a small add-on like a matching keychain).”

SCRIPT 4 — THE POLITE DECLINE

"I appreciate you asking! My prices are set to cover materials and the hours of handwork. I hope you find what you're looking for."

When a Discount Makes Sense

SITUATION	DISCOUNT APPROACH
Buyer orders multiple items at once	Offer free shipping or a small add-on, not a price cut
You want to clear older inventory	Reduce the price but mark it clearly as a sale, not the regular price
A repeat customer returns	Offer a loyalty perk (priority on new designs, a small gift) rather than a discount

Do this

Practice your response out loud before you need it. When a discount request comes in (and it will), having a ready answer prevents the panicked "okay, sure" that costs you margin.

Common mistake

Apologizing for your price. Phrases like "I know it's a lot, but..." undermine your value before the buyer even objects. State the price. Explain the value. Stop.

Discount Response Checklist

- ☐ Chosen one or two response scripts that feel natural
- ☐ Practiced saying them out loud
- ☐ Decided on a bundle or repeat-buyer perk (not a price cut)
- ☐ Written a firm but friendly "no" that I am comfortable with

SECTION 7

Packaging & Presentation

Make the unboxing experience as impressive as the backpack itself.

The moment a buyer opens the package is when they decide whether to recommend you or forget you. Thoughtful packaging does not need to be expensive — it needs to feel intentional.

The Packaging Layers

- 1 **Inner wrap** — wrap the backpack in tissue paper or a reusable fabric bag. This protects it and adds a layer of anticipation. Choose a color that complements the backpack.
- 2 **Thank-you note** — a small card that says thank you, includes care instructions and invites the buyer to share a photo. Hand-write the buyer's name if possible.
- 3 **Hang tag or label** — attach a tag with your maker name, the backpack style name and the materials used. Kraft paper tags with a simple stamp or printed label work well.
- 4 **Outer packaging** — use a sturdy mailer or box that fits the backpack without excessive empty space. Add crumpled kraft paper or air pillows to prevent shifting.
- 5 **Seal or sticker** — close the tissue paper with a branded sticker, washi tape or a simple round label. This small detail signals care.

Low-Cost Packaging Ideas

Inexpensive, High Impact

- Tissue paper in your brand color
- Kraft hang tags with a rubber stamp
- Twine or ribbon tie
- Handwritten thank-you card
- Dried flower sprig or cinnamon stick

Skip These

- Printed custom boxes (too expensive to start)
- Plastic bags (look cheap, bad for the environment)
- Excessive filler that creates waste
- Perfume or scented inserts (allergies)

Do this

Pack a test order for yourself. Open it the next day as if you were the buyer. Does it feel special? Adjust until it does. The cost of tissue paper and a tag is tiny compared to the repeat business it generates.

What to Put on the Hang Tag

INCLUDE	WHY
Your maker name or brand	So they remember who made it
Backpack style name	So they can reorder or recommend the specific design
Materials (fiber content)	Buyers with sensitivities need this
Care instructions (icons or short text)	Prevents damage and returns

Common mistake

Spending more on packaging than on profit margin. Keep packaging cost under 5–8% of the selling price. A kraft tag, tissue paper and a sticker should be enough.

Packaging Checklist

- ☐ Tissue paper or fabric wrap ready
- ☐ Thank-you cards printed or handwritten
- ☐ Hang tags with brand name, style and materials
- ☐ Mailer or box that fits the backpack with minimal extra space
- ☐ Closing sticker or tape
- ☐ Packed a test order and opened it to check the experience

SECTION 8

Growing Repeat Business

Turn a one-time buyer into a returning customer who brings others.

Finding a new buyer costs time and effort. Keeping an existing one costs almost nothing. Repeat buyers spend more, negotiate less and recommend you to friends.

Custom Orders

- 1 Define what is customizable** — color choices, size options, adding initials. Write a clear list so buyers know what they can request.
- 2 Set a custom-order surcharge** — custom work takes more communication and planning. Add a percentage to the base price (common range: 15–25% above standard).
- 3 Get approval before starting** — confirm the exact colors, size and any personalization in writing (text message, email, marketplace message). Misunderstandings on custom orders lead to disputes.
- 4 Set a timeline** — tell the buyer exactly when to expect the finished item. Add a buffer — delivering early is always better than delivering late.

Common mistake

Accepting every custom request without boundaries. If someone wants a design you have never made, a color combination that does not exist in your yarn, or a deadline you cannot meet, it is okay to say no. A declined custom order is better than a bad review.

Seasonal Collections

Give past buyers a reason to come back by releasing new designs around natural buying seasons:

SEASON	BACKPACK IDEAS	WHEN TO ANNOUNCE
Back to school	Kids' designs, bright colors, character themes	6–8 weeks before the school year starts in your area
Holiday gifting	Mini backpacks, festive colors, gift sets	Early October at the latest

SEASON	BACKPACK IDEAS	WHEN TO ANNOUNCE
Spring / summer	Cotton and linen blends, light colors, festival styles	Late winter, as people start planning warm-weather wardrobes
Everyday / year-round	Neutral tones, classic shapes, convertible designs	Always available as your staple line

Simple Ways to Stay Connected

Low Effort, High Return

- Include a card with care tips and an invitation to share a photo
- Reply to every buyer message within 24 hours
- Post work-in-progress photos to show what is coming next
- Offer early access to new designs for past buyers

As You Grow

- Start a simple mailing list for new releases
- Offer a “make your own” workshop (in person or online)
- Create a mini collection around a theme (e.g., ocean colors)
- Ask past buyers what they would like to see next

Do this

After a sale, follow up once (not more) to make sure the buyer is happy. A simple “I hope you love your backpack — let me know if you have any questions about care” is enough. This one message can turn a silent buyer into a vocal fan.

Repeat Business Checklist

- ☐ Defined what I will and will not customize
- ☐ Set a surcharge for custom orders and communicated it
- ☐ Planned at least one seasonal release for the next buying season
- ☐ Prepared a follow-up message template for after a sale
- ☐ Created a simple log of past buyers to notify about new designs

Next Step

Open the main pattern collection and choose your first backpack design. Make it, photograph it using the tips from Section 3, write the listing with the template from Section 4, and post it in your chosen sales channel. Your first sale starts with your first listing.

The Crochet Backpack Collection